

Casa de los Azulejos

Location Mexico City, Mexico

This ornate 18th-century palace, situated in what was one of the most desirable streets in the center of Mexico's capital, Francisco I. Madero Avenue, was built by the Count of the Valley of Orizaba. As its name implies, the facades of Casa de los Azulejos ("House of the Tiles") are covered in beautiful white and blue tiles in the distinctive style of the country's state of Puebla. It is considered a fine example of the Baroque architecture of New Spain, with intricate decorations inside and out, as well as an open courtyard with a fountain at its heart.

▼ WHITE AND BLUE TILING OF THE CASA DE LOS AZULEJOS IN MEXICO CITY

Metropolitan Cathedral

Location Mexico City, Mexico

One of Mexico City's most iconic buildings, the Metropolitan Cathedral sits right on the Zócalo—the city's central square. Built in stages, between 1573 and 1813, the dramatic structure is one of Latin America's largest and oldest churches. The design, by Spanish architect Claudio de Arciniega, includes Gothic, Baroque, Neo-Classical, and Neo-Renaissance influences. The Baroque front facing the square features portals with inset marble panels and bas-reliefs but is dominated by two huge bell towers. A key highlight of the interior is the gilded Altar of the Kings, built in 1718–1737 by Spanish architect and sculptor Jerónimo de Balbás.

Iglesia de la Merced

Location Quito, Ecuador

Quito, the capital of Ecuador, has the best preserved historical center in Latin America. The imposing Basílica de Nuestra Señora de la Merced, consecrated in 1747, is a fine example of its monumental buildings. It was constructed to replace an older church that was destroyed by

an earthquake. It is a beautiful but austere building with a plain white exterior. It features five domes and a tall, square tower in one corner. The church features a mix of Inca and Moorish influences—its pagan motifs include images of the Sun and the Moon. Legend has it that its tower is possessed by the devil.

